

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

What can you say of a man who weeps every time a old heritage building wipes out the past and makes way for the future, in the name of development? A man who spends all his waking hours sourcing and collecting relics from history in order to prevent them from vanishing into the folds of time? Many think he is obsessed. Others

“

If you really feel
to be done, don't
Just start doing
VIJAYNATH SHENOY

manor BORNE

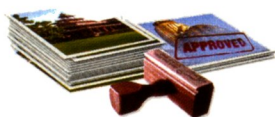
✱ Vijaynath Shenoy, 74

Project Building a heritage village from the debris of demolished historic homes

Can-do Icon None.

I do it out of compulsion, not by choice.

27 is the number of World Heritage Sites in India, while **20** more are waiting for approval



feel he is on a foolhardy mission. But the truth is Vijaynath Shenoy, a retired banker from Manipal near Mangalore, has embarked on a monumental project of preserving architectural heritage. The decade-long project is nearing its end and will be thrown open to the public by the end of this year, but Shenoy is not a happy man. "Whatever I have created, can only alleviate my pain, not bring me pleasure," he says. His sadness stems from the fact that he was a mute witness to what he calls the "destruction of beautiful architecture of his childhood".

It all started in 1997 when Shenoy began his plan to create replicas of century-old houses and build a heritage village. For the 74-year-old, preservation was something that interested him from a very young age. In the mid-1970s, he chanced upon a manor house located in the eastern valley of the Manipal hills. He was so fascinated by the rich wood-carvings of the house that he wanted to stop the owners from demolishing it. Shenoy persuaded the owners and managed to acquire the beautifully-carved wooden pillars, doors and windows of the house for a small sum of money in return. It was the beginning of a life-long obsession.

His interest in traditional houses increased over the course of time, and this interest took him to scores of villages in all parts of coastal Karnataka. From each demolished house he collected old wooden carved materials and transported them to his rented home in Manipal. When his collection piled up, he started putting them together to build a structure as his home. "I

